

Session 16: The Flood Overwhelms the Land

Key Takeaways

- The remnant suffering through chaos in a divinely provided refuge is an image that the biblical authors will use repeatedly to illustrate God's plan of rescue.
- The biblical authors confront feelings of anger, abandonment, and grief. Texts like the Psalms serve as a guide for dealing with negative emotions before God.

The Flood Overwhelms the Land: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 7:17-24

A 17 And the flood was forty days
upon the land,
and the waters were great (רבה)

B and they lifted up the ark,
and it rose up over the land .

A' 18 And the waters were mighty (גבר) ,
and they were very great (רבה)
upon the land ,

B' and the ark went on the face of the waters .

A 19 And the waters were mighty (גבר) ,
very very much,
upon the land ,

B and they covered all the high mountains which are under the skies,

A' 20 fifteen cubits above,

the waters were mighty (גבר) ,

and they covered the mountains .

21 And all flesh expired ,

what creeps on the land
with the birds
and with the beasts
and with the living creatures,
and with all the swarmers that swarm upon the land,
and all humanity,
22 all that had the inhalation of the breath of life in its nostrils,
from all that was on the dry land,

they died .

23 And he wiped away every standing-thing
that was upon the face of the land,

from humanity
to animals
to creepers
and to birds of the skies,

and they were wiped away from the land;

and only Noah was left remaining,
and those with him in the ark.

24 And the waters were mighty (גבר)
upon the land
one hundred and fifty days .

Genesis 7:17-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Notice the twin-panel composition; each one consists of an opening and closing frame around matching internal parts. It's designed as a poetic piece of epic narrative moving the story forward in graded steps to focus the reader's attention on the emphasized themes.

The “Mighty Waters”

- The verb “be mighty” (Heb. *gabar* / גַּבַּר) is the same root as “mighty warrior” (Heb. *gibbor* / גִּבּוֹר), a word that is featured in the twin introduction to the flood story (Gen. 6:4). The waters are not simply a cosmic de-creation but also a measure-for-measure response to the violence and bloodshed perpetrated by the “mighty warriors” of Genesis 6:4.
- The mighty warriors unleashed chaos and violent death into God's good world, and so he released the mighty waters to both judge their evil and purify his creation from the defilement of bloodshed.

The Mountains and the Measurement

- The small detail in Genesis 7:20 that the waters rose 15 cubits above the highest mountain is almost certainly given in order to explain why the ark could run aground on a submerged mountaintop before the waters subsided.
- The ark's measurements showed that it was 30 cubits high, and much of that would be underwater. And so the ark's bottom could only have run aground on a mountain if it was 15 cubits below the water.

The Pivot: God Remembers Noah: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 8:1

a 8:1 And Elohim remembered

b Noah
and all the living creatures
and all the beasts that were with him in the ark;

a and Elohim caused to pass

b a Spirit/wind to cover the land

c and the waters subsided.

Genesis 8:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

These two statements are the literary pivot of the entire flood narrative. They shift the story’s focus from cosmic disorder and death to rebirth and new order. Each of these statements is worded so as to reach forward and backward through design patterns in the entire Hebrew Bible.

And God Remembered

After God has handed humanity and the cosmos over to disorder, the act of new creation begins with God “remembering,” that is, recalling, his promise to Noah. This line reaches back to God’s promise to Noah in Genesis 6:17-19.

Genesis 6:17-19 **Instructor's Translation**

¹⁷ And behold, I am going to bring the flood of water upon the land, to ruin all flesh, which has in it the breath of life, from under the skies, everything that is on the land will expire,

¹⁸ and **I will set up my covenant with you**; and you will go into the ark you and your sons and your wife, and your sons’ wives with you.

¹⁹ and of every living creature of all flesh ...

God’s remembering is stage one of the fulfillment of God’s promise to rescue Noah and bring him and those with him through the waters of death.

This narrative sets the paradigm for God’s reliable commitment to his covenant promises, even when human evil has unleashed hurt and chaos into his world. Future iterations of this pattern draw upon the flood narrative, often in very creative ways.

Human Evil and God’s Deliverance Begins	“God Remembered”	Deliverance
The Flood • Human evil “ruins” (שחת) the land, God “ruins” (שחת) creation with the flood (Gen 6:5-12) • The ark (התבה) is the means of deliverance from the flood of judgment • God delivers Noah and those with him	Gen. 8:1: And God remembered Noah and all the living creatures and all the beasts that were with him in the ark	Gen. 8:4: The arks rests on Mt. Ararat, and Noah offers his sacrifice of thanks
Sodom & Gomorrah • The men of Sodom attempt to gang rape the angels • Lot’s house (הבית) and door (פתח) are the means of	Gen. 19:29: Thus it came about, when God destroyed the cities of the valley, that God remembered Abraham , and sent Lot out of the midst of the	Lot went up from Zoar, and stayed on the mountain, and sleeps with his daughters while drunk
<i>The Pattern of Human Evil and God’s Deliverance. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

Human Evil and God's Deliverance Begins	"God Remembered"	Deliverance
deliverance from the flood of evil • God announces to "ruin" (שחת, Gen. 19:13) the city, but deliver Lot	overthrow, when he overthrew the cities in which Lot lived.	
Rachel and Leah • Laban is manipulating and oppressing Jacob through deception • God "opens the door" (פתח) of Leah's womb, unleashing a flood of children and rivalry with Rachel	Gen. 30:22: Then God remembered Rachel; he listened to her	Gen. 30:22b: and God opened the door (פתח) of her womb, and she conceived and gave birth to a son, and she said, "God has gathered up my shame." And she called him Joseph.
The Exodus • The Israelites are enslaved and oppressed in Egypt • The sons of Israel are thrown into the waters of death • Moses is delivered through an ark (התבה)	Exod. 2:23–25: And the sons of Israel groaned because of the bondage, and they cried out; and their cry for help because of their bondage rose up to God. And God heard their groaning; and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. God saw the sons of Israel, and God took notice of them.	God reveals himself to Moses on a mountain and sends him to deliver Israel from Egypt
Passover • Pharaoh resists the flood of judgment in the nine plagues • The final plague is the inversion of Pharaoh's slaughter of Israelite firstborn in the Nile • The plague is carried out by the "one who ruins/destroyer" (שחת, Exod. 12:23) • Blood is applied to the door (פתח,) of the house (הבית) which should not be exited (Exod. 12:22-23)	Exod. 12:14: And today will be for you a remembrance, and you will celebrate a celebration to Yahweh Exod. 12:23: And Yahweh will pass through to strike Egypt, and he will see the blood ... and Yahweh will pass-over the door and will not let the destroyer enter your houses	The Israelites "go out" of Egypt (Exod. 12:31) to pass through the wilderness on the way to the promised land

The Pattern of Human Evil and God's Deliverance. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Reflection Question

Discuss the ways people might end up feeling like God has forgotten or abandoned them. When you see God remembering Noah, what comes to mind from your own experience of life?